

Blood-Burning Moon

Jean Toomer · 1923

First published: Cane, 1923

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/Cane_(Toomer)/Blood-Burning_Moon (revision 15075428), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about racial violence in the South?
- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about love and rivalry?
- What does Blood-Burning Moon suggest about folk song and omen?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	Blood-Burning Moon	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*racial violence in the South* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Blood-Burning Moon

Focus: love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

Content note (graphic lynching, racial slurs, knife killing. strongly recommend teacher preview): Sensitive content: Graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing. Strongly recommend teacher preview. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing. Strongly recommend teacher preview.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old factory. Louisa, unaware, sings to the moon.

Background: Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired.

Significance: A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: How can a song or image foreshadow danger? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes graphic lynching; racial slurs; knife killing. Strongly recommend teacher preview.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are canebrake, heralding, jumbled, trickle, bordering. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new." In this sentence it means: a thicket of tall cane plants. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of Blood-Burning Moon would have known. Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired. Why does this story matter? A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for imagery.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? When I find imagery, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for imagery.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of imagery. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came. Up from the dusk the full moon came. Glowing like a fired pine-knot, it illumined the great door and soft showered the Negro shanties aligned along the single street of factory town. The full moon in the great door was an omen. Negro women improvised songs against its spell.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Imagery, Symbolism, Foreshadowing: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how Blood-Burning Moon develops the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to racial violence in the South? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how imagery shapes love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
canebrake (noun)	a thicket of tall cane plants	*To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
heralding (verb)	announcing that something is coming	*Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
jumbled (verb)	mixed up in a confused way	*But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
trickle (verb)	to flow in drops	*Nails scratches let little lines of blood trickle down and mat into the hair.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
bordering (verb)	coming close (to)	*He crashed into the bordering canebrake.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
cookery (noun)	the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat	*He passed the house with its huge open hearth which, in the days of slavery, was the plantation cookery.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
embarrassed (verb)	cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious	*Then, with their eyes still upon him, he began to feel embarrassed.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
ambling (verb)	walking at a slow, easy pace	*He went towards her, ambling, touched the brim of a marvelously shaped, spotted, felt hat, said he wanted to say something to her, and then found that he didnt know what he had to say, or if he did, that he couldnt say it.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. How can a song or image foreshadow danger?
2. Where does imagery appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with racial violence in the South?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What do the women read the full moon as? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: An omen
2. Who are Louisa's two suitors? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Tom Burwell and Bob Stone
3. What building dominates the setting? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: An old pre-war cotton factory
4. How does Bob Stone die? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Tom cuts his throat in a fight
5. What does Louisa do at the end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Sings to the moon, unaware
6. Retell the three most important events of “Blood-Burning Moon” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old factory. Louisa, unaware, sings to the moon.
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “Blood-Burning Moon”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “Blood-Burning Moon” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.” What does “canebrake” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: canebrake: a thicket of tall cane plants.
10. Reread: “Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.” What does “heralding” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: heralding: announcing that something is coming.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “Blood-Burning Moon” suggest about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.
2. Find one example of imagery in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.
4. In the passage that begins “Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came.”, why might Toomer have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “Blood-Burning Moon”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Louisa, a Black woman in a Georgia factory town, is loved by Tom Burwell, a Black field worker, and Bob Stone, the son of the white family she works for. Under a full moon that the women read as an omen, Bob confronts Tom and is killed by Tom's knife. A white mob lynches Tom, burning him at the old…
6. As the opening story, what does “Blood-Burning Moon” set up that the rest of Blood-Burning Moon will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How can a song or image foreshadow danger?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does foreshadowing appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with racial violence in the South? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for hints, warnings or images that point to later events.
10. Background: Published in Cane (1923), Toomer's experimental book of stories, poems and sketches rooted in rural Georgia; US copyright term has expired. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A major Harlem Renaissance and modernist text; its lyric repetition ties folk song to violence.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of "Blood-Burning Moon" from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about "Blood-Burning Moon": one recall, one "why/how", and one "should/what if". Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to love and rivalry: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Toomer need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the imagery in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how "Blood-Burning Moon" treats love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does Blood-Burning Moon see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve racial violence in the South? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.
10. What question would you most like to ask Jean Toomer about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Imagery:** look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Foreshadowing**: hints, warnings or images that point to later events

Chapter quiz

1. What do the women read the full moon as?

   A. A blessing

   B. Nothing

   C. A sign of rain

   D. An omen

2. Who are Louisa's two suitors?
   A. Tom Burwell and Bob Stone
   B. Bob and Jim
   C. Tom and Sam
   D. Two brothers
3. What building dominates the setting?
   A. A school
   B. A church
   C. An old pre-war cotton factory
   D. A courthouse
4. How does Bob Stone die?
   A. He falls
   B. Tom cuts his throat in a fight
   C. He drowns
   D. He is shot
5. What does Louisa do at the end?
   A. Sings to the moon, unaware
   B. Flees
   C. Calls for help
   D. Joins the mob
6. In the line “To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.”, what does “canebrake” most nearly mean?
   A. announcing that something is coming
   B. mixed up in a confused way
   C. to flow in drops
   D. a thicket of tall cane plants
7. In the line “Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.”, what does “heralding” most nearly mean?
   A. a thicket of tall cane plants
   B. mixed up in a confused way
   C. to flow in drops
   D. announcing that something is coming

Answer key: 1. D (An omen); 2. A (Tom Burwell and Bob Stone); 3. C (An old pre-war cotton factory); 4. B (Tom cuts his throat in a fight); 5. A (Sings to the moon, unaware); 6. D (a thicket of tall cane plants); 7. D (announcing that something is coming)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.4, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.12, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage

your teacher selects). In “Blood-Burning Moon,” how does Toomer show love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the imagery you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): In Blood-Burning Moon, how does Toomer develop the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the imagery in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.4, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how Blood-Burning Moon develops the idea of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of imagery and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (where it begins, turns and ends) and its imagery shape the reader's understanding of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what Blood-Burning Moon suggests about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's imagery and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.4, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Jean Toomer uses imagery in Blood-Burning Moon to complicate the reader's understanding of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate Blood-Burning Moon within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read Blood-Burning Moon alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence follows or bends those conventions, using the imagery as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to Blood-Burning

Moon and its treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's imagery and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads Blood-Burning Moon as evidence for a larger claim about love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence in Blood-Burning Moon. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads Blood-Burning Moon as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on Blood-Burning Moon.

SAT-style questions

1. *But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “jumbled” most nearly mean?

   A. cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious

   B. walking at a slow, easy pace

   C. the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat

   D. mixed up in a confused way

2. *Up from the skeleton stone walls, up from the rotting floor boards and the solid hand-hewn beams of oak of the pre-war cotton factory, dusk came. Up from the dusk the full moon came. Glowing like a fired pine-knot, it illumined the great door and soft showered the Negro shanties aligned along the single street of factory town. The full moon in the great door was an omen. Negro women improvised songs against its spell.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “Blood-Burning Moon”?

   A. The art of the deadpan tall tale

   B. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

   C. Revenge carried out with perfect control

   D. A choice the reader must make

SAT key: 1. D (mixed up in a confused way); 2. B (Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence)

Whole-book test

Blood-Burning Moon: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. What do the women read the full moon as?
   A. A blessing
   B. Nothing
   C. A sign of rain
   D. An omen
2. Who are Louisa's two suitors?
   A. Tom Burwell and Bob Stone
   B. Bob and Jim
   C. Tom and Sam
   D. Two brothers
3. What building dominates the setting?
   A. A school
   B. A church
   C. An old pre-war cotton factory
   D. A courthouse
4. How does Bob Stone die?
   A. He falls
   B. Tom cuts his throat in a fight
   C. He drowns
   D. He is shot
5. What does Louisa do at the end?
   A. Sings to the moon, unaware
   B. Flees
   C. Calls for help
   D. Joins the mob
6. In the line “To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.”, what does “canebrake” most nearly mean?
   A. announcing that something is coming
   B. mixed up in a confused way
   C. to flow in drops
   D. a thicket of tall cane plants

7. In the line “Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.”, what does “heralding” most nearly mean?
   A. a thicket of tall cane plants
   B. mixed up in a confused way
   C. to flow in drops
   D. announcing that something is coming
8. As used in the story (“To meet Bob in the canebrake, as she was going to do an hour or so later, was nothing new.”), what does “canebrake” mean?
   A. a thicket of tall cane plants
   B. coming close (to)
   C. walking at a slow, easy pace
   D. to flow in drops
9. As used in the story (“Intermittently, all over the countryside dogs barked and roosters crowed as if heralding a weird dawn or some ungodly awakening.”), what does “heralding” mean?
   A. the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat
   B. announcing that something is coming
   C. a thicket of tall cane plants
   D. coming close (to)
10. As used in the story (“But for some reason, they jumbled when her eyes gazed vacantly at the rising moon.”), what does “jumbled” mean?
    A. cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious
    B. announcing that something is coming
    C. mixed up in a confused way
    D. the act of preparing something (as food) by the application of heat
11. As used in the story (“Nails scratches let little lines of blood trickle down and mat into the hair.”), what does “trickle” mean?
    A. walking at a slow, easy pace
    B. mixed up in a confused way
    C. cause to be embarrassed; cause to feel self-conscious
    D. to flow in drops
12. As used in the story (“He crashed into the bordering canebrake.”), what does “bordering” mean?
    A. coming close (to)
    B. a thicket of tall cane plants
    C. to flow in drops
    D. walking at a slow, easy pace

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how racial violence in the South develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

2. Explain how love and rivalry develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how folk song and omen develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (racial violence in the South, love and rivalry, folk song and omen) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. D (An omen); 2. A (Tom Burwell and Bob Stone); 3. C (An old pre-war cotton factory); 4. B (Tom cuts his throat in a fight); 5. A (Sings to the moon, unaware); 6. D (a thicket of tall cane plants); 7. D (announcing that something is coming); 8. A (a thicket of tall cane plants); 9. B (announcing that something is coming); 10. C (mixed up in a confused way); 11. D (to flow in drops); 12. A (coming close (to))

Essay assignments

Essay: Racial violence in the South

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about racial violence in the South. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops racial violence in the South across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of racial violence in the South. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of racial violence in the South, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of racial violence in the South in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your

critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on racial violence in the South in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Love and rivalry

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about love and rivalry. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops love and rivalry across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of love and rivalry. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of love and rivalry, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of love and rivalry in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on love and rivalry in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Folk song and omen

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what Blood-Burning Moon teaches about folk song and omen. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Jean Toomer develops folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Jean Toomer develops folk song and omen across Blood-Burning Moon. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of Blood-Burning Moon (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of folk song and omen. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Jean Toomer's choices in Blood-Burning Moon (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of folk song and omen, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places Blood-Burning Moon's treatment of folk song and omen in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on folk song and omen in Blood-Burning Moon, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Original Liber et Libri curriculum. Quotations from the public-domain text. Vocabulary definitions are modern and contextual (curated; based on Princeton WordNet 3.0). Word histories appear only where verified (Online Etymology Dictionary, 2026-10-20); other words are student look-ups. AP and Cambridge entries are our own summaries with links, not College Board or Cambridge text; ICC-WC and LeL IDs are Liber et Libri labels. Included with every curriculum purchase and with Classroom Pro.